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The Message in the Landscape

TEXTUAL ANALYSIS OF ASHOKA'S ROCK EDICTS NEEDS supplementing with context. The conclusions arrived at by examining authorial voice, political-moral agenda, and intent in using specific concepts and terms have been on the assumption that the edicts comprise a single long anthology. Analysing them as texts, however, is not enough for understanding how they were read and understood in the places where they were purposefully inscribed. The situating of documents within public spaces and arenas requires to be understood as well since the message was made a visible aspect of social and sacred landscapes. The specific histories of some of these locations till the time of Ashoka actually help us in going beyond the textual similarities of the edicts to see their contextual particularities.

The edicts were, as noted, located in the suburbs of towns, on routes travelled by caravans and used by the itinerant. The Pataliputra king's anthology was not floating unnoticed at such points, it was anchored in places that conditioned perceptions of it and possibly altered the message. Such landscapes include features that influenced how political authority was perceived, so the interpretation of this narrative of political and spiritual power was bound to depend partly on the arena within which the document was seen. Ashoka's imprint remains vivid in many of those places, a signature combination of words on rocks that acquires a resonance both from the remarkable ruins of settlements and stupas as also local traces of Mauryan intervention. In short, historicizing the regions and towns and their suburbs in which the edicts were placed is necessary.